

Common warthog

Phacochoerus africanus

Despite its rugged appearance, the common warthog is more likely to flee than fight if threatened, reaching speeds of up to 35 mph (55 km/h) on its long legs. If cornered, however, it uses its two sets of tusks to defend itself. Warthogs have reason to run—besides being hunted by humans for bushmeat, their natural predators include lions, leopards, hyenas, and crocodiles. The warthog is the only pig adapted for grazing. It “kneels” when eating grass or rooting with its tough snout, developing calluses on its wrists.

Facial armor

The warthog's facial “warts” are lumps of tissue that provide protection during fights. The warts are larger in adult males, which compete for mating rights. Females live in family groups called “sounders,” with one or more litters of piglets, and individuals communicate using squeaks, grunts, and squeals.



- ↔ 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- ⚖ 110–330 lb (50–150 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grass, roots, small animals
- 🏠 



Sub-Saharan Africa

◀ SOLITARY BOAR

Males leave their birth group after about two years and join a bachelor herd. Adult males, however, are solitary and mix with female-dominated sounders mainly to mate.

Kalahari springbok

Antidorcas hofmeyri

The name springbok refers to the way this antelope makes high, stiff-legged leaps when excited or threatened by predators, which include leopards, cheetahs, hyenas, and lions. It can leap 13 ft (4 m) through the air and reach speeds of 60 mph (100 km/h) when running away. The Kalahari springbok looks and lives much like the common springbok found to the east and south. However, this species is slightly larger and is a pale brown compared to its cousin's chestnut-red, and the band on its flank is closer to black. These are presumably adaptations to help it blend in among the arid sands and sparse vegetation of the Kalahari.

Kalahari springbok breed throughout the year. Females leave their herd when ready to give birth, usually to a single calf. They leave the calf hidden under a bush when feeding, and rejoin the herd when the calf is three or four weeks old. Calves are weaned when five or six months old, but usually stay with their mother until she next gives birth.

- ↔ 5 ft (1.5 m)
- ⚖ 67–105 lb (30.5–47.5 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grass, roots, tubers
- 🏠 



Southern Africa

▷ RACING AHEAD

Springboks spend most of the year in single-sex herds. This male herd is on the move; any stragglers will be more at risk from predators.

